

ances. Equally important, the weblog supplants the need for offline direct marketing. Customers interested in joining the author's discussion can be reached via email or simply by posting an event notice on the company's main site. Weblogs save companies millions of dollars by eliminating the need for more costly, paper communication.

The value of weblogs as critical marketing tools will only increase as they begin to include the deep analytics that are available in other forms of online marketing. Tracking and monitoring what viewers are reading and responding to results in a database of the most useful kind of customer information: individual and group behavioral trends that are based on interest in certain topics and sub-topics (versus information that is only demographic in nature). This enables companies to hone specific content and promotions for very high interest micro-audiences, which can then be delivered via the weblogs at a fraction of the cost of conventional offline and online marketing. The data gathered can also be mined and shared for future product development.

Taking the First Steps

So how does a company begin weblogging? A few simple steps are all it takes.

1. Start with a short, but explicit plan for what you want to accomplish with your weblog(s). Better customer relationships (measured by repeat sales)? A more collaborative marketing effort (measured by faster development time)? Thought leadership (measured by increased demand for commentary and publicity)? Efficient recruiting (measured by faster candidate pool for lower posting/advertising costs)?
2. Identify the right publisher(s). Your top salesperson. The head of R&D. It could be anyone who can exact business value from an online community. Just make sure he or she is articulate and committed to the idea. Look for extroverts.